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WRITING CRAFT

CLASS NOTES

A 60-minute strategy and Carrd workshop for SudoWrite authors. SudoWrite Authors

Build an author website readers trust

Build an Author Website Readers Trust

A practical planning guide for fiction authors building a focused author site in Carrd.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Your author website is not a biography archive. It is a reader journey.

A visitor should be able to answer four questions quickly:

- 01 **What do you write?**
- 02 **Is it for me?**
- 03 **Why should I trust you?**
- 04 **What should I do next?**

The aim is not to represent your entire career on one page. It is to help the right reader take one clear next step.

START WITH ONE VISITOR AND ONE ACTION

A site may eventually serve readers, existing fans, event organizers, and media contacts. On a simple one-page site, choose who the top of the page is primarily for.

Choose a primary visitor	Then choose their primary action
New reader	Buy or sample the featured book
Existing fan	Join the email list
Event organizer	Request a visit or interview
Agent or media contact	Explore the catalog or contact you

Everything else can still appear lower on the page. It simply should not compete with the main path.

Planning question: When my ideal visitor lands here, I want them to _____.

Use a verb: *read, buy, sample, join, request, book, or explore.*

THE FIVE BEATS OF A MINIMUM VIABLE AUTHOR SITE

Build the reader's path before choosing a template.

- 01 **Promise** — Name the genre, tone, or reading experience.
- 02 **Feature** — Give the reader one clear book or series entrance.
- 03 **Proof** — Offer a selective reason to trust the work.
- 04 **Connection** — Introduce the human behind the books.
- 05 **Action** — Make the next step unmistakable.

This sequence works because it moves from recognition to interest, trust, connection, and action.

CONDENSED EXAMPLE

Promise: Hopeful science fiction about impossible choices and found family.

Feature: A visible cover, a one- or two-sentence hook, and a button such as **Read the First Chapter**.

Proof: One specific review excerpt, award, credential, or meaningful reader signal.

Connection: A short bio about what you write, what animates the work, and one human detail.

Action: A newsletter signup with a concrete benefit, such as a free story or launch news.

GATHER YOUR INGREDIENTS

Preparation makes building an act of assembly rather than improvisation.

HAVE READY

- A high-resolution book cover
- A current, tightly cropped author photo
- Destination links for books, samples, and newsletter signup
- A one-sentence positioning line
- A 50–80 word bio
- One verified proof point

DECIDE BEFORE YOU BUILD

- Where does the main button go: universal link, retailer, direct store, or sample?
- What does subscribing offer the reader?
- Which book or series is the best entry point right now?

BUILD FOR CLARITY BEFORE DECORATION

A strong first screen answers “Is this for me?” in about five seconds.

Prioritize:

- Your name and a specific positioning line
- A recognizable featured cover
- A short, tension-forward hook rather than a plot summary
- One primary button whose label names the outcome
- Mobile legibility and generous spacing

Useful button labels include **Get the Book**, **Read the First Chapter**, **Join the Reader List**, and **Explore the Series**. “Click here” makes the reader do unnecessary interpretive work.

TRUST COMES FROM SELECTIVITY

More material is not automatically more persuasive.

Keep:

- One strong proof point instead of a dense praise carousel
- A relevant bio instead of a life chronology
- One display typeface and one readable body typeface
- A restrained palette drawn from the cover's atmosphere
- Repeated spacing values that make the page feel intentional

Remove anything that does not support the visitor's next step.

MAKE CONNECTION EASY, NOT DEMANDING

Every field, button, and social link asks for attention.

WORTH THE FRICTION

- An email field with a clear value exchange
- Brief privacy reassurance
- A specific confirmation message
- An accessible contact path

USUALLY NOT WORTH IT

- Long newsletter forms
- A wall of social icons above the fold
- Several buttons with equal visual weight
- Public contact details that invite spam

USE AI AS AN EDITORIAL TOOL

AI can help generate options, compress a draft, and test different phrasing. It should not invent authority, praise, credentials, or reader outcomes.

A useful copy prompt includes:

- **Goal:** What this section must help a reader decide
- **Source:** Your synopsis, positioning, tone words, and verified proof
- **Constraints:** Length, voice traits, and what to avoid
- **Output:** A limited set of options in a useful order

PROMPT PATTERN

Draft six hero headlines and three short subheads that help my ideal reader decide whether this book is for them. Use the attached synopsis, positioning, tone words, and verified proof. Avoid clichés, invented claims, and plot summary. Headlines must be nine words or fewer; subheads, twenty-four words or fewer. Preserve these voice traits: [three traits]. Put the clearest option first and explain its strategy in one sentence.

Then select, combine, revise, and read the result aloud. If it could belong to anyone, it does not yet belong to you.

LAUNCH CHECKLIST

Test the reader journey once on desktop and once on a phone.

- **Message:** Genre, promise, and next step are immediately clear.
- **Content:** Titles, dates, prices, quotations, and links are accurate.
- **Experience:** Buttons, forms, menus, and confirmation states work.
- **Trust:** Contact path, privacy language, readable contrast, and meaningful link labels are present.
- **Technical details:** Page title, description, social preview, favicon, and analytics are set.
- **Resilience:** Test in a private window and ask one reader to complete the intended task.

TAKEAWAYS

- A professional site is maintained clarity, not permanent perfection.
- Choose one primary visitor and one primary action.
- Build the reading order before styling the page.
- Specific, verified copy earns more trust than polished generic language.
- Launch version one, observe real reader behavior, and improve from evidence.

RELATED LEARNING

The same strategy applies when a site grows beyond Carrd. Multi-page author sites, catalogs, reader resources, and interactive tools still need a clear visitor, hierarchy, proof, and next step. More capability does not remove those decisions; it makes them more important.